The year also signalled the fulfilment of the second leg of the recovery programme. Tata Motor's revenues had reached a new high. It had vaulted over Rs 20,000 crore and recorded an NPAT of Rs 1,236.95 crore, Ratan announced at the AGM. Though it was a remarkable achievement, he could attain it only a full five years later than he had aimed to achieve (he had said in 1995 that he would look to quadruple the turnover of the company from Rs 5,000 crore in five years).

Ratan sourced technology from wherever he could. In 2005, he established the Tata Motors European Technical Centre (TMETC) as a subsidiary of the Indian automotive giant. This UK-based 'centre of excellence for automotive design and engineering' provided services to Tata Motors and select partners. TMETC and Trilix SRL, which Tata Motors acquired in 2010, have together designed nearly all of Tata Motors' recent cars.

The technological upgradation was all part of Ratan's effort at 'building a credible presence in selected geographies'. He said in 2006 that the company had been 'able to assemble and sell 11 % of its total output in overseas markets' and was planning to increase that 'significantly in the coming years'. He also planned for new launches, commenting that the next few years would be 'particularly exciting' for the company as it would be 'launching a range of new, technically advanced commercial vehicles and passenger cars, both in the domestic and overseas markets'.

In 2006, Tata Motors unveiled the Tata Cliffrider, a multiutility lifestyle vehicle. Simultaneously, it established a 51:49 JV with Marcopolo SA, Brazil to manufacture fully built buses and coaches for the domestic and foreign markets. It also set up a 70:30 JV with Thonburi Automotive Assembly Plant in Thailand to build and market pick-up trucks in the Thai market. It entered a collaboration with Fiat S.p.A. of Italy, which gave it access to the technological reservoir of the company. The Brazilian collaboration particularly benefited the group. The quality of Marcopolo-built bodies was 'amazing' and it made the buses the market leaders in Tanzania, Zambia and Uganda, says Kamal Rohira, head, Auto Business, Tata International, Kenya.

The last JV, with Fiat, however, turned out to be a mixed bag. Ratan himself admitted that it was not 'as active as' he had thought it would be. However, it resulted in the production of 1,90,000 cars and 3,37,000 power trains and was involved in the production of cars such as the Palio, Punto